

Rationalism — MCQ Solutions

Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Western Philosophy | Topic 02

Open only after attempting the corresponding question. Each solution preserves the complete canonical answer, four option explanations and the examiner trap.

CONTENTS

Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

MCQ 1. What the rationalist thesis actually asserts	3	MCQ 18. Attributes, modes and the contrast with Descartes	12
MCQ 2. Which rule of method does the destructive work	3	MCQ 19. "Whatever is, is in God"	13
MCQ 3. The order of the three doubts	4	MCQ 20. Pantheism, panentheism and acosmism	13
MCQ 4. The logical status of "I am, I exist"	4	MCQ 21. Necessity in Ethics I	14
MCQ 5. The limits of what the thinking self establishes	5	MCQ 22. Parallelism as a solution to the mind-body problem	15
MCQ 6. Sorting the three kinds of ideas	6	MCQ 23. The three kinds of knowledge and the fourth proportional	15
MCQ 7. What Descartes means by an innate idea	6	MCQ 24. Definition 7 and the meaning of Spinozist freedom	16
MCQ 8. Locke's grounds of refutation	7	MCQ 25 (remedial). The provenance of "all determination is negation"	16
MCQ 9. What the wax argument establishes	7	MCQ 26 (remedial). Perception is not consciousness	17
MCQ 10. Why imagination cannot do the work	8	MCQ 27 (remedial). Individuality and the status of bodies	17
MCQ 11. Matching the proofs of God to their strategy	8	MCQ 28 (remedial). Harmony, influence and assistance	18
MCQ 12. The Cartesian Circle and the reply	9	MCQ 29 (remedial). Two kinds of truth and two kinds of necessity	19
MCQ 13. The proof of the external world	10	MCQ 30 (remedial). What Leibnizian freedom requires	19
MCQ 14. The argument for the real distinction	10	MCQ 31 (remedial). Attribution and provenance in answer-writing	20
MCQ 15. The interaction problem and the pineal gland	11	MCQ 32 (remedial). What a comparative answer must contain	20
MCQ 16. Error and the grades of freedom in Meditation IV	11		
MCQ 17. Spinoza's argument for one substance	12		

MCQ 1. What the rationalist thesis actually asserts

Consider the following statements about early-modern rationalism.

1. It denies that sense-experience can by itself supply the warrant for necessity and universality.
2. It holds that the structure of reality is accessible to reason, and explains that structure through substance, attribute and mode.
3. It maintains that sensory beliefs are uniformly false and that the physical world is an illusion.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it couples the sound thesis about warrant with a caricature; Descartes devotes the whole of Meditation VI to *restoring* the material world rather than abolishing it. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate but statement 3 attributes to the school a position Spinoza expressly rejects when he classes sense-based imagination as a genuine, if inadequate, kind of knowledge. - **C:** Correct: the two load-bearing commitments are the claim about warrant and the claim that an intelligible reality is to be articulated through a metaphysics of substance, attribute and mode. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three converts a thesis about justification into a thesis about illusion, which no member of the trio holds.

Examiner trap 1: Defining rationalism as hostility to the senses is the commonest opening error in this topic. Define it by the **source of warrant** for necessary truth, and the rest of the answer stays on the syllabus.

MCQ 2. Which rule of method does the destructive work

In the *Discourse on the Method*, Part II, Descartes states four rules. The rule that generates the wholesale demolition of Meditation I is the rule requiring him to

- A. divide every difficulty under examination into as many parts as its solution requires
- B. conduct his thoughts in order, beginning with the simplest and easiest objects
- C. accept nothing as true which he does not clearly and evidently know to be so
- D. make his enumerations so complete and his reviews so general that nothing is omitted

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: analysis is a rule of problem-management inherited from mathematical practice; by itself it removes no belief whatever. - **B:** Incorrect: proceeding from simple to complex organises an inquiry that is already under way and cannot license the suspension of whole classes of belief. - **C:** Correct: once assent is withheld from whatever is not evident, and a single counterexample renders a whole class non-evident, the senses, the world and even mathematics can be suspended in turn. - **D:** Incorrect: complete enumeration is a rule of review that guards against omission at the end of an inquiry, not a principle of demolition at its beginning.

Examiner trap 2: Listing the four rules without saying which of them does the work turns a philosophical method into a memorised quartet. Name rule one as the engine of the *Meditations*.

MCQ 3. The order of the three doubts

Match each stage of Cartesian doubt with what it is designed to remove.

1. Sense-deception — 2. The dream argument — 3. The evil genius (*genius malignus*)

I. Even the simple truths of arithmetic and geometry. II. The reliability of particular perceptual judgements about how things appear. III. The immediate perceptual situation, and with it the whole external world.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–II, 2–III, 3–I

B. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

C. 1–I, 2–II, 3–III

D. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the stages are cumulative — sense-deception unsettles particular perceptual judgements, the dream argument removes the situation and the world, and only the deceiver hypothesis reaches mathematics. - **B:** Incorrect: it makes the weakest doubt do the strongest work and leaves the deceiver hypothesis attacking what the first stage had already unsettled. - **C:** Incorrect: it exactly inverts the sequence, so that mathematics falls first and the world falls last, destroying the argumentative escalation. - **D:** Incorrect: it correctly places sense-deception but then reverses the two later stages, which removes the reason Descartes needs the deceiver at all.

Examiner trap 3: The order is itself an argument, because each stage attacks precisely what the previous stage left standing. Reporting the three doubts as an unordered list forfeits the structure the examiner is testing.

MCQ 4. The logical status of "I am, I exist"

Descartes' claim that he exists whenever he thinks is best characterised as

A. an inductive generalisation drawn from many observed instances of his own thinking activity

- B. a deduction from the suppressed major premise that whatever thinks must exist
- C. an empirical report of an inner sensation whose occurrence he happens to notice
- D. an immediate intuition whose certainty is performative and confined to the present moment

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: an induction would yield only a probable generalisation, whereas Descartes needs a proposition that resists a supremely powerful deceiver. - **B:** Incorrect: Descartes explicitly denies that the *cogito* is a syllogism concealing a general premise, and says instead that it is recognised by a simple intuition of the mind. - **C:** Incorrect: treating it as an inner observation makes it one more piece of evidence that the deceiver hypothesis could in principle contaminate. - **D:** Correct: the certainty is generated by the act of thinking itself and holds whenever the proposition is put forward or conceived, which is exactly why deception cannot touch it.

Examiner trap 4: Writing "*cogito, ergo sum*" and adding "therefore it is an inference" contradicts Descartes in the same sentence. The "therefore" belongs to the Latin tag of the *Discourse* and the *Principles*, not to the logic of the *Meditations*.

MCQ 5. The limits of what the thinking self establishes

Consider the following statements about what the *cogito* by itself establishes.

1. That thinking is occurring, and that the thinker exists while thinking.
2. That the thinker is an enduring immaterial substance numerically identical over time.
3. That there is at least one proposition immune to the hypothesis of a powerful deceiver.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: statement 2 imports the substantial soul, which Descartes reaches only through the further work of Meditation II and the real distinction of Meditation VI. - **B:** Correct: present thinking existence and immunity to the deceiver are precisely what the argument delivers, and nothing more. - **C:** Incorrect: it pairs a genuine result with the unearned claim about diachronic identity, which is the gap Lichtenberg and Hume later exploit. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three collapses the distinction between the certainty of the act and the metaphysics of its subject.

Examiner trap 5: Candidates routinely let the *cogito* prove the immortality of the soul in one line. Concede the narrowness of the result and then show how Descartes argues for more; the concession is worth more marks than the overreach.

MCQ 6. Sorting the three kinds of ideas

Match each class of idea with its correct description.

1. Adventitious (*adventitiae*) — 2. Factitious (*factitiae*) — 3. Innate (*innatae*)

I. Native to the mind's own rational nature and elicited on an appropriate occasion. II. Received as though from outside, arriving involuntarily through a passive faculty. III. Constructed voluntarily by the mind out of ideas it already possesses.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–II, 2–III, 3–I

B. 1–I, 2–II, 3–III

C. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

D. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: adventitious ideas arrive involuntarily, factitious ideas are built by the mind at will, and innate ideas belong to the intellect's constitution. - **B:** Incorrect: it makes the involuntary class native and the native class constructed, which destroys the causal argument of Meditation III. - **C:** Incorrect: it treats made-up ideas as involuntary arrivals, so the golden mountain would need an external cause of its own. - **D:** Incorrect: it correctly identifies the first class but exchanges the other two, so voluntary construction becomes native endowment.

Examiner trap 6: The classification is not decorative. It exists so that the idea of God can be placed in the third class and its content argued to exceed what a finite mind could manufacture.

MCQ 7. What Descartes means by an innate idea

The strongest formulation of Cartesian innateness — the one that Locke's appeal to the absence of universal assent does not reach — is that an innate idea is

A. a proposition consciously affirmed by every human being from the earliest moment of life

B. a sensory impression so frequently repeated that it has become impossible to doubt

C. an image stored in the memory before birth and later recovered by a distinct act of recollection

D. a native disposition of the intellect which produces the idea on an appropriate occasion

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is the occurrent version of the doctrine, and it is exactly the version Locke destroys by pointing to children who affirm no such principles. - **B:** Incorrect: grounding the idea in repeated sensation concedes the empiricist's central claim and abandons the rationalist thesis about warrant. - **C:** Incorrect: pre-natal storage and recollection belong to the Platonic tradition; Descartes

speaks of seeds of knowledge in the mind's constitution, not of retrieved images. - **D**: Correct: innateness is dispositional — the mind is so constituted that, given an occasion, it produces the idea from its own resources.

Examiner trap 7: A 2023-style answer that presents the occurrent version and then reports Locke's refutation has staged a contest in which one side never got up. Always state the dispositional version first.

MCQ 8. Locke's grounds of refutation

Consider the following as grounds on which Locke rejects innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I.

1. Alleged innate principles command no universal assent, since children and others do not affirm them.
2. Nothing can be said to be in the mind and yet unknown to it, on pain of making every knowable truth innate.
3. The idea of infinity is demonstrably richer than anything the mind could ever construct from finite materials.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A**: Incorrect: statement 3 is a Cartesian premise for innateness, not a Lockean objection to it; Locke argues the opposite, that infinity is reached by repetition and negation. - **B**: Correct: the absence of universal assent and the transparency of mental content are Locke's two principal tests, supported by his positive derivation of ideas from sensation and reflection. - **C**: Incorrect: it pairs a genuine Lockean test with a claim that belongs to the side Locke is attacking. - **D**: Incorrect: including statement 3 makes Locke argue for the doctrine he devotes Book I to dismantling.

Examiner trap 8: Omitting **reflection** misstates Locke. His two sources of ideas are sensation *and* the mind's observation of its own operations, and a script that mentions only sensation invites an easy correction.

MCQ 9. What the wax argument establishes

The conclusion the wax argument of Meditation II is designed to secure is that

- A. the wax has no real properties at all once its sensible qualities have been destroyed by heat
- B. bodily identity through qualitative change is grasped by the intellect rather than by sense

- C. the senses are wholly inoperative and contribute nothing whatever to any human judgement
- D. the existence of external material bodies follows directly from the persistence of the wax

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the wax retains extension, flexibility and changeability; the argument removes the sensible catalogue, not the object. - **B:** Correct: every item in the sensible catalogue is replaced while the same wax is still judged to remain, so the vehicle of that judgement cannot be sense. - **C:** Incorrect: Descartes' point is that what passes for seeing is judging, not that seeing has ceased; the "hats and coats" case makes exactly this distinction. - **D:** Incorrect: existence is restored only in Meditation VI through divine veracity, and confusing the two is among the most heavily penalised errors in this topic.

Examiner trap 9: The wax proves *how* body would be known, never *that* body exists. Saying so explicitly, and in one sentence, is itself worth a mark in the 2019-style question.

MCQ 10. Why imagination cannot do the work

In the wax argument, the reason Descartes rejects imagination as the faculty by which the wax is grasped is that

- A. imagination is always accompanied by a sensory impression and so inherits every sensory defect
- B. imagination belongs to the body and is therefore extinguished whenever the body is altered
- C. heat can give the wax indefinitely many shapes, which no finite run of images could ever exhaust
- D. imagination operates only on objects that are absent, whereas the wax is present to him

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the argument does not turn on imagination inheriting sensory defects; it turns on a mismatch between an indefinite range and a finite capacity. - **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the passage makes imagination cease when the wax is heated, and the claim would prove far more than Descartes needs. - **C:** Correct: this is the force of "flexible and changeable" (*flexibile et mutabile*) — the possible shapes are indefinite in number and cannot be run through in images. - **D:** Incorrect: the presence or absence of the object is irrelevant, since the argument concerns the range of possible forms rather than their availability to sense.

Examiner trap 10: Answers that jump from "not sense" straight to "therefore intellect" skip the step that does the real work. Imagination must be eliminated separately, and by the indefiniteness of the possible shapes.

MCQ 11. Matching the proofs of God to their strategy

Match each Cartesian proof of God with its distinctive argumentative move.

1. Trademark or causal — 2. Conservation — 3. Ontological

I. Existence is contained in the concept of a supremely perfect being, so its denial is a contradiction. II. I cannot sustain my own existence from one moment to the next, so a continuing cause is required. III. The content of my idea of an infinite being exceeds anything a finite mind could have produced.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–III, 2–II, 3–I

B. 1–I, 2–III, 3–II

C. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

D. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the causal proof works from the objective reality of the idea, the conservation proof from my momentary dependence, and the ontological proof from the concept alone. - **B:** Incorrect: it makes the trademark proof conceptual and the ontological proof causal, reversing the very feature that distinguishes them. - **C:** Incorrect: it assigns momentary dependence to the trademark proof and conceptual necessity to conservation, so no proof retains its own premise. - **D:** Incorrect: it opens correctly but then swaps conservation with the ontological route, losing the division of labour among the three arguments.

Examiner trap 11: Naming the division of labour among the three proofs earns more than reciting all three at length. Each answers a different question — where the idea came from, what sustains me, and what the concept contains.

MCQ 12. The Cartesian Circle and the reply

Arnauld's objection in the Fourth Objections, and Descartes' reply to it, are best stated as follows:

A. the objection is that God cannot be proved at all, and the reply is that the idea of God is innate rather than voluntarily made

B. the objection is that the *cogito* is really a syllogism, and the reply is that it is an immediate intuition

C. the objection is that the senses cannot ever be trusted, and the reply is that a perfect God would never deceive

D. the objection is that the criterion proves God who certifies it, and the reply separates attended from remembered perception

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: innateness answers a question about the origin of the idea, not the charge that the proof presupposes what it establishes. - **B:** Incorrect: this correctly describes a different exchange about the logical form of the *cogito*, which Arnauld's circularity charge does not concern. - **C:** Incorrect: divine veracity is the conclusion under attack, so citing it as the reply simply restates the position

Arnauld is challenging. - **D:** Correct: the charge is circularity between criterion and guarantee, and Descartes replies that a perception actually before the mind compels assent while God secures memory and extended reasoning.

Examiner trap 12: The reply must be followed by its residual weakness: the proofs of God are themselves extended arguments whose earlier premises are remembered rather than attended, so the circle is softened rather than removed.

MCQ 13. The proof of the external world

Consider the following steps in Descartes' Meditation VI argument for material things.

1. Sensory ideas arrive involuntarily, so I possess a passive faculty of receiving them.
2. I have a great natural inclination to refer these ideas to bodies, and no faculty by which the inclination could be corrected.
3. The wax argument has already demonstrated that at least one extended body exists outside me.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 misassigns to the wax argument an existential conclusion it expressly does not reach. - **B:** Incorrect: it retains the correct claim about natural inclination but again treats the wax as an existence proof. - **C:** Correct: involuntariness establishes a passive faculty needing an active cause, and the uncorrectable inclination makes any alternative attribution a divine deception. - **D:** Incorrect: including statement 3 imports a conclusion from Meditation II that Meditation VI is written precisely to supply.

Examiner trap 13: Compressing this into "God guarantees the world" throws away the whole question. The 2019 examiner is marking a five-step causal argument, not a slogan.

MCQ 14. The argument for the real distinction

The reasoning by which Descartes concludes that mind and body are really distinct proceeds by holding that

- A. whatever can be clearly and distinctly conceived apart can by God's power exist apart, and so is distinct
- B. whatever is observed to behave independently in the course of ordinary experience must be a separate substance
- C. whatever has a different location in the body must belong to a different kind of created thing

D. whatever survives the hypothesis of the evil genius is thereby shown to be immaterial in nature

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the inference runs from clear and distinct separate conception, through divine omnipotence, to real separability and hence real distinction. - **B:** Incorrect: observed independence is precisely the sort of empirical premise the *Meditations* has already suspended, and it could not yield a metaphysical conclusion. - **C:** Incorrect: location is a property of extended things alone, so an argument from location cannot establish that anything unextended exists. - **D:** Incorrect: surviving the deceiver shows that the *cogito* is indubitable, not that its subject is immaterial; that further claim needs the separability argument.

Examiner trap 14: Dualism is a **conclusion** of the Cartesian system, drawn from the criterion of truth and divine omnipotence. Presenting it as an unargued starting assumption misrepresents the architecture and loses the link to Session 5.

MCQ 15. The interaction problem and the pineal gland

Descartes' appeal to the pineal gland, and Princess Elisabeth's objection to his position, are best understood as follows:

- A. the gland is the seat of the soul, a claim Elisabeth accepts while denying that any such soul can be immortal
- B. the gland gives interaction a location, while Elisabeth asks how the unextended could move the extended
- C. the gland is the organ of imagination, which Elisabeth argues should instead be assigned to the intellect
- D. the gland dissolves the problem entirely, and Elisabeth's objection concerns only the physiology of the nerves

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: immortality is not the issue in the 1643 correspondence, which turns on the intelligibility of causal commerce between the two substances. - **B:** Correct: Descartes offers a site, chosen because the gland is unpaired and central, whereas Elisabeth's question is about a mechanism, which no site can supply. - **C:** Incorrect: the dispute is not about which faculty is housed where, but about how any causal influence across the real distinction is possible. - **D:** Incorrect: Descartes himself does not claim that the gland dissolves the difficulty; his considered reply is that the union is a primitive notion.

Examiner trap 15: Treating the pineal gland as Descartes' answer misses his real answer. The philosophical reply is that the mind–body union is a third **primitive notion**, known through ordinary living rather than through pure intellect.

MCQ 16. Error and the grades of freedom in Meditation IV

According to Descartes' account of error and freedom, error arises because the will is

- A. finite while the intellect is infinite, so that understanding constantly outruns what may be affirmed
- B. determined by bodily motions, so that assent is compelled by mechanical causes outside the mind
- C. most free when it is wholly indifferent, since indifference alone leaves alternatives genuinely open
- D. infinite in scope while the intellect is finite, so that assent may be given beyond clear perception

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it exactly reverses the two faculties, and on that reversal error could never occur, since nothing would be affirmed beyond what is understood. - **B:** Incorrect: making assent mechanically compelled would remove the responsibility for error that Meditation IV is written to establish. - **C:** Incorrect: Descartes ranks indifference as the *lowest* grade of freedom, since the will is most free when moved by clearly perceived truth. - **D:** Correct: the infinite will can affirm or deny anything, the finite intellect perceives clearly only within limits, and error is assent given outside those limits.

Examiner trap 16: The claim that indifference is the highest freedom is the reverse of Descartes' text. Getting the ranking right also strengthens the later contrast with Spinoza, for whom freedom likewise increases with adequate understanding.

MCQ 17. Spinoza's argument for one substance

The demonstration by which Spinoza reaches a single substance turns essentially on the premise that

- A. two substances cannot share an attribute, so nothing whatever could distinguish them as substances
- B. God is defined at the outset as the only being whose essence involves its own existence
- C. extension is divisible and therefore cannot belong to what is ultimately real in nature
- D. thought and extension are known to us, while infinitely many further attributes remain unknown

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: from the impossibility of shared attributes it follows that a finite substance would need limiting by one of the same nature, so substance must be infinite and unique. - **B:** Incorrect: self-causation is established in the course of the argument rather than stipulated, and stipulating it would make the demonstration circular. - **C:** Incorrect: this is Leibniz's objection to extended substance, and Spinoza retains Extension as an attribute expressing the whole divine essence. - **D:** Incorrect: the limitation of human knowledge to two attributes is a consequence of the system, not a premise from which uniqueness could be derived.

Examiner trap 17: Asserting monism without the no-shared-attribute step reduces a demonstration to a slogan. The 2022 and 2024 questions both reward the derivation rather than the conclusion.

MCQ 18. Attributes, modes and the contrast with Descartes

For Spinoza, thought and extension are best described as

- A. two finite modes which together exhaust the content of the one infinite substance
- B. two created substances which depend for their existence on the infinite substance
- C. two attributes, each expressing the whole eternal essence of the one substance
- D. two aspects of human perception which do not correspond to anything in substance

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: modes are affections existing in another and conceived through another, whereas an attribute is what the intellect perceives as constituting substance's essence. - **B:** Incorrect: this is precisely the Cartesian position Spinoza rejects, and importing it collapses the whole point of difference between the two systems. - **C:** Correct: each attribute expresses the whole essence, not a portion of it, and substance possesses infinitely many of which we know these two. - **D:** Incorrect: reducing attributes to features of human perception makes them subjective, whereas Spinoza needs them to be real expressions of substance.

Examiner trap 18: Confusing Spinoza's **attributes** with Descartes' **substances** is the single most damaging error in comparative questions, because it destroys the explanation of why parallelism replaces interaction.

MCQ 19. "Whatever is, is in God"

In *Ethics* I, P15 and P18 together, the claim that whatever is, is in God, is best understood as asserting that

- A. finite things are spatially contained within a divine body that extends throughout the whole universe
- B. finite things exist as modes of the one substance, whose immanent and not transitive cause is God
- C. finite things were produced by an act of will at a moment in time and are conserved by divine choice
- D. finite things are appearances with no reality of their own, since only the infinite is genuinely real

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the containment is ontological rather than spatial, and a spatial reading would make God a very large extended object among others. - **B:** Correct: modes exist in and are conceived through substance, and P18's immanent causation means the cause remains in the effect rather than producing something outside itself. - **C:** Incorrect: Spinoza denies deliberation and temporal creation; modes follow from what substance is, not from a discretionary decree. - **D:** Incorrect: this states Hegel's acosmism charge rather than Spinoza's doctrine, which grants modes a dependent but genuine reality.

Examiner trap 19: The preposition carries the doctrine. Reading "in God" spatially converts an argument about ontological dependence into an image, and the 2024 question is marked on the argument.

MCQ 20. Pantheism, panentheism and acosmism

Consider the following statements about the standard labels applied to Spinoza's God.

1. Pantheism, in the qualified sense that nothing exists outside God and all things are modes within the one immanent substance.
2. Acosmism, the charge associated with Hegel that if only substance is real then the finite world dissolves into nothing.
3. Panentheism, the reading on which all things are in God while God exceeds the finite modes and the two attributes we know.

Which of the statements given above correctly describe positions taken in the interpretive debate?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: omitting the panentheist reading removes the very option that best captures why substance is not exhausted by the world we perceive. - **B:** Incorrect: dropping the qualified pantheist reading leaves out the position most commentators regard as the primary description of the system. - **C:** Incorrect: omitting acosmism removes the strongest objection in the debate, which is that Spinoza denies rather than deifies the world. - **D:** Correct: all three are genuine positions in the dispute, and a defensible answer states the qualified pantheism, answers the acosmism charge and notes the panentheist alternative.

Examiner trap 20: Pantheism and acosmism are **opposite** accusations — one that the world is made divine, the other that it is made nothing. Treating them as the same objection makes the 2022 answer incoherent.

MCQ 21. Necessity in *Ethics* I

Consider the following statements about Spinoza's necessitarianism.

1. P16 holds that infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature.
2. P29 holds that nothing in nature is contingent, apparent contingency recording only ignorance of causes.
3. The derivation is ontological rather than temporal, so it is not a story in which God first exists and later produces a world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: leaving out the ontological character of the derivation permits the common misreading of P16 as a narrative of creation. - **B:** Incorrect: omitting P16 removes the proposition the 2020 question actually quotes, and with it the source of the infinity claim. - **C:** Incorrect: dropping P29 loses the explicit denial of contingency on which the whole account of freedom subsequently rests. - **D:** Correct: the three statements together give the content, the consequence and the modality of Spinoza's necessity.

Examiner trap 21: Necessity here is logical and ontological, not an external compulsion pushing things about. Describing it as fate imports an agent that Spinoza's system does not contain.

MCQ 22. Parallelism as a solution to the mind–body problem

Spinoza's doctrine that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things has the consequence that

- A. a mental event and a bodily event are one and the same single mode expressed under two attributes
- B. mental events cause bodily events, but only through the mediation of the infinite intellect
- C. bodily events cause mental events, since the mind is the idea of an already existing body
- D. mental and bodily events belong to two substances whose sequences God continually adjusts

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: because the two orders are the same order, a decision and a movement are not two items in causal commerce but one mode twice expressed. - **B:** Incorrect: any mediation across attributes would reinstate the cross-attribute causation the doctrine exists to exclude. - **C:** Incorrect: although the mind is the idea of the body, the relation is one of expression rather than production, and causation remains within each attribute. - **D:** Incorrect: continual divine adjustment is occasionalism, a rival seventeenth-century position that Spinoza's monism makes unnecessary.

Examiner trap 22: The two-parallel-trains image quietly restores two things running side by side. Spinoza's claim is stronger and simpler: there is one thing, described completely in two ways.

MCQ 23. The three kinds of knowledge and the fourth proportional

In Spinoza's example of finding the fourth proportional to 1, 2 and 3, the merchant who applies a remembered rule, the mathematician who demonstrates it from the common property of proportionals, and the person who sees at once that the answer is 6, exemplify respectively

- A. reason, imagination and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy
- B. imagination, intuitive knowledge and reason, since demonstration is the highest form
- C. imagination, reason and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy

D. intuitive knowledge, reason and imagination, since immediacy is the least reliable

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it makes rule-following from signs the second kind, whereas learning a rule by hearsay is precisely the first kind's mode of operation. - **B:** Incorrect: it ranks discursive demonstration above the single adequate act, reversing Spinoza's own ordering in *Ethics* V. - **C:** Correct: the merchant knows only that, from signs and vague experience; the mathematician knows adequately but discursively; the third grasps the ratio in the essences themselves, in one act. - **D:** Incorrect: it treats immediacy as a defect, whereas for Spinoza the immediacy of intuitive knowledge is what makes it the highest kind.

Examiner trap 23: The three kinds are three **ontological positions of the knower**, not three degrees of confidence. That formulation is what converts an epistemology answer into an answer about freedom.

MCQ 24. Definition 7 and the meaning of Spinozist freedom

Ethics I, Definition 7 states that a thing is free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone. This definition contrasts freedom with

- A. causation as such, so that a free act must be an event without any determining cause whatever
- B. external compulsion, so that a thing is free as far as it acts from its own understood nature
- C. rational deliberation, so that freedom belongs to spontaneous impulse rather than to understanding
- D. divine necessity, so that human freedom consists in an exemption from the general order of nature

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: an uncaused event is exactly what Spinoza denies is possible, and the definition speaks of self-determination rather than of the absence of determination. - **B:** Correct: freedom is opposed to being determined by causes external to one's nature, which is why adequate ideas increase freedom rather than diminishing it. - **C:** Incorrect: it inverts the doctrine, since for Spinoza it is precisely understanding that converts passive impulse into free action. - **D:** Incorrect: no exemption from the causal order is available in Spinoza's system, and only God is free in the absolute sense the definition describes.

Examiner trap 24: The word to circle in Definition 7 is "alone". Freedom is opposed to **compulsion**, never to **causation**, and every strong answer on the 2023 quotation says so in its first two lines.

MCQ 25 (remedial). The provenance of "all determination is negation"

Which of the following statements about the formula *omnis determinatio est negatio* is correct?

- A. It is a proposition of *Ethics* I, demonstrated immediately after the definition of substance itself
- B. It is a phrase of Descartes, later applied to Spinoza by nineteenth-century commentators

- C. It universalises a remark in Spinoza's Letter 50 and entered the textbooks through Hegel
- D. It is a formulation of Leibniz, used to explain why no two monads can be exactly alike

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the exact Latin formula does not appear in the *Ethics* at all, and citing it there is a verifiable factual error. - **B:** Incorrect: the remark is Spinoza's own, made in correspondence, and has no Cartesian source. - **C:** Correct: Spinoza writes *determinatio negatio est* in Letter 50 of 2 June 1674, and the universalised slogan is Hegel's rendering, which is how it entered the tradition. - **D:** Incorrect: the identity of indiscernibles is a distinct Leibnizian doctrine grounded in the Principle of Sufficient Reason.

Examiner trap 25: Getting the provenance right is worth a mark on its own in the 2025 question. Write "Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation — universalised by Hegel", and the sentence does two jobs at once.

MCQ 26 (remedial). Perception is not consciousness

Which of the following correctly states Leibniz's position on the mental life of monads?

- A. Every monad has perception, but only some have the reflexive awareness called apperception
- B. Every monad has apperception, since a perception without any awareness would be a contradiction
- C. Only rational spirits have perception, while lower monads possess appetite alone
- D. Only God has perception, and created monads merely reflect it without possessing it

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: perception is the representation of the manifold in the simple and need not be conscious; minute perceptions (*petites perceptions*) fall below the threshold of awareness. - **B:** Incorrect: this collapses the distinction on which Leibniz's whole hierarchy rests and makes the roar of the sea inexplicable. - **C:** Incorrect: appetite is the transition *between* perceptions, so a monad with appetite and no perception would have nothing to pass between. - **D:** Incorrect: created monads genuinely perceive; each is described as a perpetual living mirror of the universe from its own point of view.

Examiner trap 26: Writing that monads are conscious points of force makes the hierarchy of bare monads, animal souls and rational spirits unintelligible. Perception is universal; apperception is not.

MCQ 27 (remedial). Individuality and the status of bodies

Consider the following statements about Leibniz's account of individuality and of extended bodies.

1. No two monads are exactly alike, since God would have no sufficient reason to create indistinguishable duplicates.

2. An organism is coordinated by a dominant monad together with an aggregate of subordinate monads.
3. Extended bodies are well-founded phenomena, grounded in ordered monadic aggregates rather than being arbitrary illusions.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: omitting the status of bodies leaves the system open to the false charge that Leibniz simply denies the physical world. - **B:** Incorrect: dropping the identity of indiscernibles removes the doctrine that guarantees individuality, which is Leibniz's principal motive against Spinoza. - **C:** Incorrect: leaving out the dominant monad removes Leibniz's account of what makes an organism one thing rather than a heap. - **D:** Correct: the three doctrines together secure unique individuals, organic unity and an objective though non-ultimate status for bodies.

Examiner trap 27: The adjective in "well-founded phenomena" is doing the work. Dropping it turns Leibniz into a subjective idealist, which he is not, and forfeits the contrast with both Descartes and Spinoza.

MCQ 28 (remedial). Harmony, influence and assistance

Leibniz distinguishes his own solution to the mind–body question from two rivals. His position is that the correspondence between mental and bodily series is secured by

- A. a continuous divine adjustment of both series at every moment, as occasionalism maintains
- B. a single arrangement made at creation, so that each series unfolds internally and they agree
- C. a direct causal link between the two series, located in a central and unpaired organ of the brain
- D. an identity between the two series, since they are one and the same thing described in two ways

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is the "assistance" option, which Leibniz rejects as unworthy of a perfect craftsman who would not need to keep correcting his own work. - **B:** Correct: harmony is established once, at creation, so that windowless monads unfold internally and yet correspond perfectly, as two perfectly made clocks keep the same time. - **C:** Incorrect: this is the "influence" option, that is, Descartes' interactionism, which windowlessness rules out in principle. - **D:** Incorrect: identity of the two series is Spinoza's parallelism, which Leibniz rejects because it sacrifices the plurality of substances.

Examiner trap 28: Describing harmony as continuous divine intervention converts Leibniz into an occasionalist. Naming all three options — influence, assistance, harmony — and rejecting two is what turns an image into an argument.

MCQ 29 (remedial). Two kinds of truth and two kinds of necessity

Which of the following correctly distinguishes Leibniz's two kinds of truth and the modal claim he derives from them?

- A. Truths of reason are contingent and analysable only infinitely, whereas truths of fact are necessary and can be analysed finitely
- B. Both kinds are necessary, and the only difference lies in whether human beings are able to complete the analysis
- C. Truths of reason are necessary with finite analysis; truths of fact are contingent, and their necessity is only hypothetical
- D. Both kinds are contingent, since God could have chosen a world in which the truths of mathematics were different

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both halves of the distinction, so that mathematics becomes contingent and historical events become necessary. - **B:** Incorrect: making both kinds necessary is exactly the necessitarian conclusion Leibniz constructs the distinction to avoid. - **C:** Correct: the opposite of a truth of reason implies a contradiction, while the opposite of a truth of fact remains conceivable and is realised in another possible world. - **D:** Incorrect: Leibniz holds that truths of reason are governed by the principle of contradiction and hold in every possible world, so no divine choice could alter them.

Examiner trap 29: Absolute necessity and hypothetical necessity are the hinge of the freedom answer. Without that distinction, the complete individual concept makes every act necessary and Leibniz collapses into the necessitarianism he opposes.

MCQ 30 (remedial). What Leibnizian freedom requires

Leibniz's account of human freedom requires which of the following conditions to hold together?

- A. Indifference of the will, absence of divine foreknowledge, and the reality of chance in nature
- B. Spontaneity alone, since any action arising from the agent's own inner nature is by that very fact free
- C. Intelligence and contingency alone, spontaneity being ruled out by the windowlessness of monads
- D. Spontaneity, intelligence and contingency, with reasons inclining the will without necessitating it

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: Leibniz rejects indifference explicitly, affirms complete divine foreknowledge, and denies that anything happens without a sufficient reason. - **B:** Incorrect: spontaneity by itself would make a falling stone free, which is why deliberation for perceived reasons must be added. - **C:** Incorrect: windowlessness does not remove spontaneity but guarantees it, since nothing external can compel a monad's states. - **D:** Correct: the three conditions are jointly necessary, and the formula that reasons incline without necessitating (*incliner sans nécessiter*) states the kind of determination involved.

Examiner trap 30: Answering the 2018 or 2020 question with spontaneity alone leaves out two thirds of the doctrine. All three conditions must appear, and the necessity distinction must be stated alongside them.

MCQ 31 (remedial). Attribution and provenance in answer-writing

Which of the following attributions is correct?

- A. "The ghost in the machine" is Gilbert Ryle's hostile description of Cartesian dualism, coined in 1949
- B. "The ghost in the machine" is Descartes' own summary of the union of mind and body
- C. "The best of all possible worlds" is Voltaire's doctrine, which Leibniz satirised in his *Theodicy*
- D. "The order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things" is from the *Monadology*

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the phrase is Ryle's coinage in *The Concept of Mind* (1949), and attributing it correctly turns a common error into a mark-earning observation. - **B:** Incorrect: Descartes never uses the phrase, and it is designed by a hostile critic to make his position sound absurd. - **C:** Incorrect: the direction of influence is reversed — the doctrine is Leibniz's, and Voltaire's *Candide* of 1759 is the satire of it. - **D:** Incorrect: the sentence is Spinoza's *Ethics* II, P7, and misplacing it in Leibniz confuses parallelism with pre-established harmony.

Examiner trap 31: Provenance errors are cheap to avoid and expensive to make. Three recur constantly in this topic: Ryle's phrase, Voltaire's satire, and the Letter 50 formula.

MCQ 32 (remedial). What a comparative answer must contain

In answering a question that asks whose account of the mind–body problem is compatible with human freedom, the feature that most distinguishes a high-scoring script is that it

- A. narrates all three systems in sequence, giving each an equal number of lines and no conclusion
- B. announces the criterion of freedom being used, ranks all three against it, and defends the ranking
- C. selects one philosopher at the outset and expounds him at length without discussing the others
- D. lists the standard criticisms of each position and leaves the reader to adjudicate between the three

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: equal narration without adjudication answers the topic rather than the question, and the directive "critically discuss" makes a verdict compulsory. - **B:** Correct: because compatibility depends entirely on what freedom is taken to require, the criterion must be declared before any ranking can be defended. - **C:** Incorrect: the question is explicitly comparative, so an exposition of one thinker leaves two thirds of the demand unaddressed. - **D:** Incorrect: collecting criticisms without ruling between them is exactly the failure the "critically" in the directive is designed to detect.

Examiner trap 32: A comparison without an announced criterion is a list. State the standard, rank against it, defend the ranking, and concede what the winner costs — that sequence is the difference between a describing script and a deciding one.